

C. GENERAL RULES AND TECHNICAL RECOMMENDATIONS FOR TOURNAMENTS /

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GENERAL RULES AND REGULATIONS

Approved by FIDE Council on 11/12/2025

Applied from 01/03/2026

1. Complementary to the FIDE Handbook, the FIDE Technical Commission (TEC) has compiled the **[TEC Manual]**(<https://tec.fide.com/fide-technical-manual/>) containing comprehensive information, including definitions, processes, and clarifications essential for understanding and implementing FIDE technical regulations.

2. Definitions

- 2.1 **Acceptance** is the formal acknowledgment of **compliance** with specific rules and regulations. It confirms adherence to the established standards, allowing the **Product** to be officially recognised.
- 2.2 **Bug** is a flaw, error, or unintended behaviour in **software** that causes incorrect results, malfunctions, or deviations from expected functionality. **Bugs** may affect **performance, accuracy, stability, security, or user experience** and can be classified as **minor, major, or critical** based on their impact.
- 2.3 **Accepted Product** is a product that received a **TAPC** and still has a valid **TAPC**.
- 2.4 **Command Line Interface (CLI)** is a text-based user interface used to interact with a computer or **software** system. Instead of using graphical elements like buttons or menus, users type **commands** into a terminal or console to perform tasks.
- 2.5 **Compliance** refers to the act of adhering to the laws, regulations, guidelines, or standards by FIDE. It involves following specific rules and regulations to meet legal obligations and mitigating risks by adhering to prescribed guidelines and regulations.

- 2.6 **Credible Complaint** is grievance or allegation presented with sufficient supporting information, logical consistency, and specificity to be considered believable and worthy of further inquiry.
- 2.7 **Defect** is any deviation from the required specifications, standards, or expected functionality of a **Product** as defined by FIDE regulations. **Defects** may be functional, **compliance**-related, performance-based, hardware-related, **software**-related, or safety-related.
- 2.8 **Equipment Owner** refers to an individual or company who possesses and owns a piece of equipment but is neither its original **manufacturer** nor a vendor who sells it.
- 2.9 **FIDE Endorsement of Accepted Product (FEAP)** means that the **manufacturer** has successfully entered into a commercial agreement with FIDE, and as a result, FIDE publicly expresses **approval** and support for the **Product**.
- 2.10 **Manufacturer** refers to the maker of the **Product** and is interchangeably used with the term **Vendor** throughout this document. This designation applies to the entity responsible for the design, production, and **Compliance** of the **Product** with FIDE standards.
- 2.11 **Product** refers to any **software** (including web applications, mobile applications, and drivers), hardware devices, or services for which the **manufacturer** seeks a **SDPC**, **TAPC**, or **FECP**.
- 2.12 **Self-Declaration of Product Compliance (SDPC)** refers to the formal process where an Organiser, **Equipment Owner** or **Manufacturer** signs a declaration affirming that their **Product** fully meets all the technical specifications, rules, and regulations set forth in both the FIDE Handbook and the **TEC Manual**.
- 2.13 **Software** is a collection of instructions, data, or programs used to operate computers and execute specific tasks. It encompasses a broad range of digital solutions, including web applications, mobile applications, drivers, and desktop programs.
- 2.14 **TEC Manual** is the [FIDE Technical Commission Manual](<https://tec.fide.com/fide-technical-manual/>)
- 2.15 **Technical Acceptance of Product Compliance (TAPC)** involves a review process to ensure **Compliance** with the relevant criteria before granting official consent.
- 2.16 **Verification Checklist (VCL)** is a structured, itemised list outlining specific criteria, standards, and requirements that a **Product** must meet, or recommendations that a **Product** should preferably meet. The checklist

systematically confirms whether each requirement is fulfilled, ensuring accuracy, **Compliance**, and consistency.

- 2.17 **Version** refers to Semantic versioning. See [Semantic Versioning](<https://semver.org/>), where it is written to describe a **version** number as MAJOR.MINOR.PATCH, with the following meaning:
 - 2.17.1 A MAJOR **version** change happens when incompatible changes are made.
 - 2.17.2 A MINOR **version** change happens when new functionalities are added in a backward compatible manner.
 - 2.17.3 A PATCH **version** change happens when backward compatible **bug** fixes are made.
 - 2.17.4 Additional labels for pre-release and build metadata are available as extensions to the MAJOR.MINOR.PATCH format.

3. Acronyms

- 3.1 **AC** – Acceptance Cycle
- 3.2 **FEAP** – FIDE Endorsement of **Accepted Product**
- 3.3 **TAPC** – Technical Acceptance **of Product Compliance**
- 3.4 **NRD** – New Rules Date
- 3.5 **SDPC** – Self Declaration **of Product Compliance**
- 3.6 **PTC** – Pairings and Tie-Break Checker
- 3.7 **RTG** – Random Tournament Generator
- 3.8 **VCL** – **Verification Checklist**
- 3.9 **TEC** – FIDE Technical Commission
- 3.10 **THP** – Tournament Handler Program
- 3.11 **TP** – Transition Period
- 3.12 **TRF** – Tournament Report File

4. Classification of Products

- 4.1 Chess Equipment without electronic components (See section **Chess Equipment without Electronic Components** under **Chess Equipment Technical Specifications, Rules and Regulations**):
 - 4.1.1 Boards
 - 4.1.2 Mechanical Clocks
 - 4.1.3 Paper Score Sheets
 - 4.1.4 Pieces
 - 4.1.5 Tables and Chairs

4.2 Chess Equipment with electronic components (See section **Chess Equipment with Electronic Components** under **Chess Equipment Technical Specifications, Rules and Regulations**):

- 4.2.1 Cameras / Video Capturing
- 4.2.2 Digital Clocks
- 4.2.3 Electronic Boards
- 4.2.4 Electronic Scoresheets
- 4.2.5 Hybrid Tournament Management
- 4.2.6 Fair Play Detection **Software**
- 4.2.7 Publishing Hardware
- 4.2.8 Publishing **Software**
- 4.2.9 Tournament Handler Programs (historically called Pairing Programs)

5. **General Rules and Guidelines**

- 5.1 Only online applications, requests and proposals will be accepted. Online forms or processes can be found at [TEC Online Forms](<https://www.cognitofirms.com/FIDE/TECMenu>).
- 5.2 In all FIDE or Continental Championships, Olympiads, and other FIDE-registered tournaments, the chess equipment provided by the organisers shall adhere to the standards detailed below. See **General Regulations for Competitions** for the list and levels of tournaments.
- 5.3 **Manufacturers** must register at and maintain their details at [TEC Online Forms](<https://www.cognitofirms.com/FIDE/TECMenu>).
- 5.4 **TEC** holds the authority to determine if any piece of equipment is appropriate for use in official FIDE competitions, making its assessment in accordance with the technical standards.
- 5.5 **SDPC** and **TAPC** are only possible if the technical specifications and rules are defined in the FIDE Handbook or published in the **TEC Manual** and updated as necessary.
- 5.6 All applicable and relevant specifications, rules, and regulations for the **Product** must be in place and adequate. If at any point during the application process it is found that the required rules and technical specifications for the **Product** or system have not yet been established, or

are not adequate, the application process will be put on hold until such standards are formally defined or updated.

- 5.7 **Manufacturers** have the right to request that FIDE establish the necessary rules and technical specifications if they are not already in place. However, it remains solely at the discretion of FIDE whether to comply with such requests and create the needed definitions.

- 5.8 A testing fee shall be charged for all **Products** seeking a **TAPC** or **FEAP** in accordance with the fee structure published in the **TEC Manual, Annexure A – Fees**.

5.8.1 A **one-time initiation fee** will be charged for all **Product** testing.

5.8.2 An **additional fee per Product classification** will be charged on top of the initiation fee.

5.8.3 **Manufacturers** may request preliminary testing of their **Product** to refine their project before pursuing a full **TAPC**. This preliminary testing is considered separate from the official **TAPC** process and may involve associated fees. Once the relevant rules and technical specifications are determined, and the **manufacturer** is ready to proceed with the acceptance, a new application for the official **TAPC** must be submitted.

5.8.4 The fees are payable regardless of if a **TAPC** or **FEAP** is issued or not.

5.8.5 **Manufacturers** must refer to the latest **version** of the **TEC Manual** for updated fee structures and payment procedures.

- 5.9 All **software** must be **versioned** with at least a major and minor **version**. See [Semantic Versioning](<https://semver.org/>) for details.

- 5.10 All **Products** must comply fully with FIDE rules and standards.

- 5.11 **Revocation of a TAPC** (For detailed procedures, refer to the **TEC Manual**):

5.11.1 **Automatic Revocation**

The **TAPC** will be automatically revoked under the following conditions:

- a. On the effective date of a change in FIDE Rules, Regulations, or Specifications that impacts the Product's compliance.
- b. A major version update introduced by the manufacturer for software or drivers associated with Products containing electronic components.

- c. A physical parameter change introduced by the manufacturer for non-electronic Products.
- d. It is the manufacturer's responsibility to inform FIDE if any condition for automatic revocation is met. Failure to notify FIDE may result in the permanent cancellation of the .

5.11.2 **Manual Revocation (By FIDE Decision)**

- a. If FIDE receives a **Credible Complaint** about the **Product**.
- b. If a known **software bug** or driver issue is not resolved within a reasonable timeframe.

5.11.3 **Tightly integrated/dependant hardware and software:**

- a. If the **software** is installed on different hardware than the original **TAPC**, **TEC** have sole discretion to require a re-testing of the **Product** on the new hardware.

5.12 While **TEC** will make every effort to collaborate with **manufacturers** to achieve **Product** acceptance, if **TEC** ultimately rejects the **Product** for acceptance, the producer must remove the **SDPC** from any official platform where it was displayed. Additionally, the producer will be prohibited from submitting a new **TAPC** application for a period of one year.

5.13 The **Products** listed in FIDE Endorsed Equipment constitute the exclusive set of items that hold a **TAPC**.

5.14 Fair Play and security devices are administered and overseen by the Fair Play Commission.

6. **Self-Declaration of Product Compliance**

6.1 **SDPC** can be requested by an Organiser, **Equipment Owner** or **Manufacturer**.

6.2 **SDPC** can only be obtained for **chess equipment without electronic components**.

6.3 The party completing the **SDPC**, as per article 5.1, must complete and submit the specific online **VCL** (refer to <https://www.cognitofrms.com/FIDE/TechMenu>).

6.4 Once **SDPC** is issued, the equipment in question must be clearly marked with the **SDPC** number provided by FIDE.

7. **Technical Acceptance of Product Compliance (TAPC)**

- 7.1 A **TAPC** is granted only when all the following conditions are met:
 - 7.1.1 The **SDPC** form was submitted.
 - 7.1.2 All applicable fees have been paid in full.
 - 7.1.3 All required forms, as published and periodically updated by FIDE, have been properly filled out and submitted.
 - 7.1.4 **TEC** has conducted all necessary testing.
 - 7.1.5 An English-language datasheet or detailed specifications document is available.
 - 7.1.6 An English-language user manual (when required) is also provided.
 - 7.1.7 **TEC**'s recommendations receive final **Approval** from the FIDE Council, or the FIDE General Assembly.
- 7.2 In cases involving equipment without electronic components, the Chief Arbiter of a tournament may apply for a "**Temporary TAPC**" before the event begins. This temporary acceptance remains valid only for the duration of the event and for up to one month in total.
- 7.3 Rules and Regulations for Testing a **Product**
 - 7.3.1 A minimum of three testers will be appointed to assess the **Product**. These testers are chosen at the sole discretion of the Chairman of **TEC**.
 - 7.3.2 **The Product** must be provided with all required accessories (cables, adapters, sensors, etc.), licenses, functional **software** to control, operate, and manage the equipment's features and compatibility.
 - 7.3.3 The **manufacturer** must pay the fees specified in the **TEC Manual** to **TEC**.
 - 7.3.4 The **manufacturer** must send the equipment to the designated testers at the **manufacturer**'s own expense.
 - 7.3.5 **TEC** will, where necessary, inform and collaborate with other FIDE bodies to obtain assistance and expertise during the testing and review process.
 - 7.3.6 The final **Product** submitted to the tester must be the exact item for which the acceptance will be issued:
 - a. Equipment without electronic components:
The tester must physically have the

final **version** of the **Product** (e.g., boards and pieces) intended to receive acceptance.

- b. Equipment with electronic components: The tester must physically have the final **version** of the **Product** loaded with the latest **software version** intended to receive acceptance (e.g., clocks and digital boards).
- c. **Software** falls under the "equipment with electronic components" category. The tester must have the latest **version** of the **software** (e.g., Tournament Handler Programs) that will be made available to the community for acceptance.

7.3.7 The testers will evaluate the **Product** using the same **VCL** employed by the **manufacturer** during the **SDPC** process. This ensures consistency in the evaluation criteria and alignment with FIDE's standards.

7.3.8 The testers will compile a detailed report, which must be approved by the Chairman of **TEC**. This report is then submitted to the FIDE Council for final **Approval**.

- 7.3.9 Once a **TAPC** is granted, the **manufacturer** must:
- a. Send a fully functional sample of the **Accepted Product** to the FIDE Office for archival storage, at the **manufacturer's** own cost.
 - b. Arrange for the testers to return the **Product** to the **manufacturer** after testing, including covering all related shipping costs and making all necessary arrangements.

7.4 The following **Products** are eligible for a **TAPC**:

The list below is not comprehensive and will be amended from time to time.

7.4.1 Boards, including non-electronic and electronic.

7.4.2 Broadcasting equipment

7.4.3 Chairs

7.4.4 Clocks, including mechanical and electronic.

7.4.5 Pieces

- 7.4.6 Publishing Hardware
- 7.4.7 Publishing **Software**
- 7.4.8 Score Sheets, including paper and electronic
- 7.4.9 Tables
- 7.4.10 Tournament Handler Programs (historically called Pairing Programs)
- 7.5 A **TAPC** cannot be issued for **Products** like:
 - 7.5.1 Administration Systems

If the administration system includes a Tournament Handler, the Tournament Handler can obtain a **TAPC**.
 - 7.5.2 Chess Openings
- 7.6 The FIDE Council authorises the issuance of the **TAPC** based on the recommendation of **TEC**. Once approved, the **Product** will be recorded in the **FIDE Accepted and Endorsed Equipment Register**.
- 7.7. Endorsement is only possible for **Products** that have already obtained a valid **TAPC**.
- 7.8 Holding a **TAPC** does not automatically guarantee endorsement. To receive endorsement, the **manufacturer** must successfully enter into a commercial agreement with FIDE, approved by the FIDE Council
- 7.9 In situations where formal acceptance cannot be obtained, FIDE reserves the exclusive right to decide, at its own discretion, whether to endorse the **Product** or not.
- 7.10 On the "Applied Date" reflected at the top of this document, the status of all **Products** that do not have an Endorsement agreement" with FIDE will be changed to **TAPC** for the current **version** of the **Product** in production.
- 7.11 All **TAPC**'s are subject to the conditions specified in Annexure A - Acceptance Letter

8. Usage of Equipment at Tournaments (See General Regulations for Competitions)

- 8.1 FIDE Level 1 Tournaments (L1):
 - 8.1.1 Endorsed **Products** are required unless waived by FIDE Council.
 - 8.1.2 If there are more than one endorsed **Product**, it is the choice of the Organiser which endorsed **Product** to use.

- 8.1.3 If there are no endorsed **Product**, the Organiser can use any **Accepted Product**.
- 8.2 FIDE Level 2 Tournaments (L2):
 - 8.2.1 Endorsed **Products** are recommended. **Accepted Products** are tolerated.
- 8.3 FIDE Level 3 Tournaments (L3):
 - 8.3.1 Endorsed and **Accepted Products** are recommended. Self-Declared Compliant **Products** are tolerated.
 - 8.3.2 The Chief Arbiter can authorise the use of Equipment lacking the prescribed acceptance level. See **General Regulations for Competitions** under **General Rules and Technical Recommendations for Tournaments**.

Annexure A - Acceptance Letter